

Call Prep: Russell Frees — Henricksen (Intro Call)

2:00–2:30 PM CDT (19:00–19:30 UTC) | 30 min | Microsoft Teams (link, meeting ID, and passcode confirmed on invite) | New contact — no 1:1 meeting has actually occurred yet

Calibration note: This is a peer/relationship introduction, not a sales-sourced lead. It was set up by a mutual contact (Rex Miller) and Russell has explicitly framed it as wanting to learn how Improving's clients are navigating AI in their industry — not as a discovery call for a deal. Do not pitch a specific Improving service today. Treat it as a two-way exchange between peers.

Who They Are

Company	Henricksen
Industry	Contract furniture dealership / commercial workplace solutions
HQ	Oak Brook, Illinois (new HQ/showroom at 1301 W. 22nd Street, Floor 11, completed 2026)
Founded	Not found
Size	13 offices nationwide; represents 400+ manufacturers
Email domain	henricksen.com

Company Overview

Henricksen is a leading full-service contract furniture dealership now spanning 13 offices and 400+ manufacturer relationships. The company is in active growth/consolidation mode: it recently acquired Synergy Business Environments, rebranded its COFCO subsidiary fully under the Henricksen name, and just completed a new flagship HQ and showroom in Oak Brook, IL. Leadership bench is being built out to support that growth — several promotions in the past few months point to deliberate expansion into new practice areas and a push to unify service delivery across a growing office footprint.

Recent news:

- Bob Batley promoted to Managing Director, Architectural Products — Frees quoted on Batley's role bringing the 13 nationwide offices closer together and deepening the Allsteel partnership
- Chris Knoepfel elevated to Chief Growth Officer
- Gina Parker appointed Director of Healthcare Strategy; Brian Homiak promoted to Manager of Architectural Solutions Operations — both signal vertical expansion
- COFCO, a Henricksen Company, opened a new Experience Center and rebranded fully to Henricksen

- New Henricksen HQ (1301 W. 22nd St, Oak Brook, IL) completed 2026 — dual-purpose office and showroom

Strategic initiatives:

- Growth by acquisition (Synergy Business Environments) and brand consolidation (COFCO → Henricksen)
- Vertical build-out: architectural products practice, healthcare strategy
- Unifying the 13-office footprint under a consistent leadership and service model — explicitly named by Frees himself in the Batley promotion announcement

Competitive/market pressures:

- Henricksen is the consolidator here (acquiring and rebranding), which reads as a growth signal rather than a defensive move
- Scaling service consistency across a rapidly growing multi-office footprint is the challenge Frees is actively speaking to in his own leadership communications

Sources: company website (henricksen.com newsroom) + web search (CCR-Mag, officeinsight, Crunchbase, LeadIQ). No prior CRM history or Improving engagement found for Henricksen.

Who He Is

- **Title:** President and CEO, Henricksen (confirmed via email signature and henricksen.com)
- **Education:** Miami University
- **Location:** Illinois (Oak Brook HQ base)
- **Public-facing work:** Active on LinkedIn; quoted directly in Henricksen's own leadership-promotion press releases, signaling he's a hands-on, visible communicator about company direction
- **LinkedIn:** <https://www.linkedin.com/in/russellfrees/>

"Read on him": Strategy-focused CEO actively driving growth and consolidation at Henricksen — not a technology buyer. Calibrate as a peer exploring how other leaders are thinking about AI, not a prospect for a specific Improving service.

Common Connections

LinkedIn mutual connections were not checked for this run. A prior check found a 500+ connection profile with second-degree mutuals present but could not extract specific names.

Reason for the Call

Russell Frees (President + CEO, Henricksen) was introduced to David by Rex Miller (rex@gomindshift.com) via email dated July 3, 2026, subject "Connecting you with David O'Hara." Russell replied July 9, 2026, expressing interest to "connect more and learn about how you are seeing your clients navigate the AI in their space... certainly been pushing into our space." David replied the same day welcoming the conversation. This Teams call (invite sent August 18, 2026,

subject "Introductory call | Russell Frees and David O'Hara") is that intro call finally landing on the calendar.

Do not assume:

- This is not a sales opportunity or pipeline activity — no CRM or sales touch found in email; this is a peer/relationship referral.
- Do not assume urgency or a defined business problem — Russell is exploring and learning, not responding to a crisis.
- Do not assume this is a second meeting or repeat conversation — there's no evidence an earlier scheduling attempt for this call ever actually occurred; treat this as the first live touchpoint.
- Do not pitch a specific Improving service in the opening.

Suggested Talking Points / Questions

1. **AI adoption reality in his space:** Ask Russell what he's seeing in the contract furniture industry around AI adoption — what's working, what's not, where clients push back and where they lean in.
2. **Activation vs. replacement:** Share how Improving frames AI (activating human capability rather than replacing people) and ask how that lands against what he's seeing in workplace/furniture.
3. **Growth and consolidation as context:** Henricksen is actively acquiring, rebranding, and expanding into new verticals (healthcare, architectural products) right now — worth asking how AI factors into scaling service consistency across 13 offices, a challenge he's already speaking to publicly.
4. **Reciprocal learning:** Share a pattern or two from what Improving's clients are learning about AI adoption, and ask what would be most useful for him to hear given where Henricksen is right now.

Landmines / Notes

- Don't pitch. Russell is deciding whether this is worth an ongoing relationship, not sitting through a discovery call.
- Don't lead with Improving's services — he's curious how you think, not what you sell.
- Don't assume Henricksen needs software or consulting — let him signal where value might exist.
- Don't dominate the air time — this should be a two-way exchange.

Open Questions Going In

- No evidence was found that an earlier scheduling attempt for this same intro call ever actually took place — worth quietly confirming this is in fact the first conversation, not a reschedule David should reference.
- No stated agenda beyond the intro — Russell may pivot to a specific topic or keep it broad.

- Unclear whether this is a one-off conversation or the start of an ongoing relationship — notice whether Russell signals interest in follow-up.
- LinkedIn mutual connections not verified for this run — status unknown going in.